

General HR Policy and Code of Conduct

1. Introduction

This General HR Policy and Code of Conduct establishes the standards of behaviour, professional conduct, and workplace values expected of all employees. All employees are required to read, understand, and comply with this policy. Adherence to this policy is a condition of employment. The company reserves the right to update this policy and will provide reasonable notice of any material changes to all staff.

2. Equal Opportunity and Non-Discrimination

The company is committed to equal opportunity in all aspects of employment including recruitment, training, promotion, and termination. Employment decisions are based solely on merit, qualifications, and business requirements. Discrimination, harassment, or victimisation based on age, gender, race, ethnicity, religion, disability, sexual orientation, or any other protected characteristic is strictly prohibited. Any employee found to have engaged in discriminatory behaviour will be subject to disciplinary action up to and including termination of employment. The company also commits to making reasonable adjustments for employees with disabilities.

3. Professional Conduct and Workplace Behaviour

All employees are expected to conduct themselves in a professional, respectful, and collaborative manner at all times. This includes interactions with colleagues, clients, suppliers, and any other third parties encountered in the course of work. Employees must avoid behaviour that could bring the company into disrepute, including inappropriate use of social media, misrepresentation of the company's products or services, and conduct that could create a hostile work environment. Concerns about workplace behaviour should be raised through the formal grievance process.

4. Confidentiality and Data Protection

All employees have a duty to maintain the confidentiality of company information, client data, and personal data of colleagues. Confidential information must not be disclosed to unauthorised parties inside or outside the organisation without proper authorisation. Employees who handle personal data must comply with applicable data protection laws including the UK GDPR. Personal data must be collected and processed only for specific, legitimate purposes and must not be retained longer than necessary. Any data breach or suspected breach must be reported to the Data Protection Officer within 24 hours of discovery.

5. Working Hours and Remote Work

Standard working hours are Monday to Friday, 09:00 to 17:30, with a 30-minute unpaid lunch break. Employees are expected to work their contracted hours. Flexible working arrangements may be agreed with the line manager and HR subject to business requirements. Remote working is available for roles where operationally feasible and must be approved by the employee's manager. Employees working remotely are expected to maintain the same level of availability, output, and professional standards as when working on-site.

6. Performance Reviews and Development

All employees undergo a formal performance review at least once per year. Reviews are conducted by the employee's line manager and focus on achievement against objectives, demonstration of company values, and identification of development opportunities. Employees are encouraged to provide self-assessments and identify their own learning and

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development needs. Salary reviews are conducted annually and are informed by the performance review outcome, market benchmarking, and the company's financial performance for the year.

7. Disciplinary Procedures

Where an employee's conduct or performance falls below the expected standard the company will follow a fair and transparent disciplinary process. The stages are: informal discussion, formal verbal warning, written warning, final written warning, and termination of employment. The appropriate starting point depends on the severity of the issue. Gross misconduct, including but not limited to theft, fraud, violence, serious breach of confidentiality, and harassment, may result in immediate termination without prior warning. All employees have the right to be accompanied by a colleague or trade union representative at any formal disciplinary hearing.

8. Grievance Process

Employees who have a concern or complaint about their working conditions, treatment, or any aspect of their employment are encouraged to raise it promptly. In the first instance employees should attempt to resolve the matter informally with their line manager. If this is not possible or appropriate, a formal grievance may be submitted in writing to HR. HR will acknowledge the grievance within 5 working days and arrange a formal hearing. Employees have the right to be accompanied at the hearing. A written outcome will be provided within 10 working days of the hearing. Employees who are dissatisfied with the outcome may appeal to senior management within 10 working days of receiving the outcome letter.